

Danielle and Dave never really had enough. Dave's employment was sporadic, and he liked to sink money into big dreams that never materialized. And Danielle often left the financial planning to him, since the kids were her primary concern. The sisters stayed close throughout their lives, despite their very different paths.

Eventually, Danielle's long-term care began to entirely drain Dave's savings. He began to ask his children, who did well in life, to pitch in a little for the monthly costs of keeping their mother in the home she'd come to love. But Danielle was also getting sicker. She was less and less aware of her surroundings and increasingly disappearing into that awful disease, which made it hard for her to even know who was visiting her anymore. The kids asked Dave to consider a more affordable facility. Dave, however, didn't want to move Danielle. After tapping his kids for as much as they could afford, he asked Danielle's sister, Amanda, to help. After all, the sisters were so close and she and Lyle had a very comfortable nest egg. Surely they could part with a few hundred dollars a month to subsidize Danielle's costs. That's all he was asking for.

Amanda and Lyle talked long into the night about it. They came to a painful decision. The next day, Amanda said no to Dave. They weren't willing to pay for Danielle to stay in that home. They suggested it was time for Dave to move her to the more affordable nursing home down the road—the one that accepted Medicaid.

It's an all-too-common story. You may be thinking that the problems started with Dave's bad investments. Maybe you think Amanda and Lyle were selfish. Danielle was her beloved sister, and what were they using their money for, anyway? Maybe you think Danielle's kids owed her more. Maybe the problem goes back even further, to Danielle, who, knowing how bad her husband was with money and investing, should have been setting aside her own funds for just such an emergency. Bad money patterns make themselves clear early on, and if they're not corrected, they only get worse. You can stay married to someone like Dave, but you have to work hard to extricate yourself financially, in the interest of self-preservation.

I am with Amanda and Lyle on this. I completely agree with their decision, a very difficult one. They have to think about their own late-